

HOUSE RESOLUTION 205

By Freeman

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Coach Josh Clark and the Montgomery Bell Academy debate team upon winning the 2026 Policy Debate Tournament of Champions.

WHEREAS, the members of this legislative body take great pleasure in recognizing those outstanding Tennesseans whose achievements bring honor to our State and serve as a source of pride for their communities; and

WHEREAS, Montgomery Bell Academy, an all-boys college preparatory school in Nashville, is widely respected for its commitment to developing gentlemen, scholars, and athletes, a guiding ideal that reflects the school's dedication to cultivating character, intellectual rigor, and leadership among its students; and

WHEREAS, the Montgomery Bell Academy debate program has once again distinguished itself at the highest level of national academic competition, demonstrating exceptional intellectual rigor, discipline, and teamwork; and

WHEREAS, under the leadership of Director of Debate Josh Clark, the Montgomery Bell Academy debate team captured the 2026 Policy Debate Tournament of Champions, the most prestigious national championship in high school policy debate, widely regarded as the pinnacle of the activity; and

WHEREAS, seniors Russell Howard and Jimmy Li earned the national title after advancing through one of the most competitive fields in the country, defeating top-ranked teams from across the United States and internationally; and

WHEREAS, seniors Res Seibels and Oliver Johnston advanced to the semifinals of the Tournament of Champions, while senior Fox Travis and junior Enno Brandes also advanced to the quarterfinals; and

WHEREAS, further demonstrating the program's exceptional depth and national competitiveness, the Montgomery Bell Academy debate program placed three teams in the national quarterfinals, with an additional team advancing to the semifinals and finishing third in the nation—just one round shy of an all-MBA final; and

WHEREAS, this achievement marks the third Tournament of Champions victory in Montgomery Bell Academy's history, with previous championships in 1999 and 2020, and reflects a program that has reached the final round five times in the past seven years; and

WHEREAS, this victory caps a historic season in which the debate team established itself as the number-one-ranked policy debate team in the nation and also earned The David P. Baker Award, the premier, season-long honor in United States high school policy debate, presented by the National Debate Coaches' Association; and

WHEREAS, over the course of the season, the championship team won five of the seven major tournaments it entered, an extraordinary accomplishment reflecting sustained excellence; and

WHEREAS, Josh Clark's leadership, mentorship, and commitment to academic excellence have played an instrumental role in cultivating one of the nation's premier debate programs and the most decorated high school policy debate team in history, inspiring students to excel in critical thinking, research, and civic engagement; and

WHEREAS, the accomplishments of these students and their coach exemplify the very best of Tennessee's commitment to educational excellence and serve as an inspiration to students across the State; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, that we honor and commend Coach Josh Clark and the Montgomery Bell Academy debate team for winning the

2026 Policy Debate Tournament of Champions and extend to them our best wishes for continued success in all their future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy.